infrastructure and governance are radically transformed. He aims to bring the best minds together and foster collaboration across sectors. If that recalls an armchair theoretician, PK literally took that idea to the ground. He was often seen sitting cross-legged in the simplest of village settings, listening intently, taking questions, discussing solutions. His message: for Bihar to rise, the people must *demand* better governance, not as beneficiaries of political patronage but as stakeholders. It's hard to ignore the energy and momentum he has generated. His movement is built on the well-reasoned and verifiable premise that Bihar's youth are eager for change, tired of the status quo, and hungry for opportunities that allow them to contribute meaningfully without having to migrate.

The Challenges

That requires strategising on a grand scale, and Prashant is not flinching from it: Jan Suraaj intends to contest all 243 seats in the assembly elections. But if there's one thing PK is not, it's naive. He understands how entrenched Bihar's political culture is, with powerful vested interests that have historically resisted change. But his deepest challenge may be caste. Primarily, his own: he's a Pandey, a Brahmin. It's not just that the group constitutes only 4 per cent of Bihar's population (while being the single-largest among the privileged castes), leaving him vastly disadvantaged in a state where about 85 per cent of the population belongs to non-elite castes. At a deeper level, the idea of a Brahmin aiming for the top sits antithetical to the spirit of caste emancipation that has driven Bihar's political energies for decades. Therefore, PK's disruptive language occupies a delicate node where he perforce has to appeal against caste-based politics but must avoid the risk of being called out as elitist.

The strategist in him has sought to pre-empt that criticism by ruling himself out of the leadership race. The party, instead, will rotate leadership among different social groups in a formula designed for proportional representation. PK is believed to favour having a Dalit as the first president—the segment constitutes 19.7 per cent of Bihar's population. When the assembly election comes around, PK plans to field approximately 70 candidates from the Extremely Backward Classes (EBC), who form around 36 per cent of Bihar's population. He has also promised at least 40 Muslim candidates—roughly matching their 17.7 per cent population ratio. The rotational leadership plan, too, is likely to see an EBC or a Muslim as the second president. A certain paradox attends to this, of course. The format may be designed to be inclusive, but can invite the question of why exactly it should merit the tag of being mould-breaking—pragmatically crafted proportional representation is exactly what all traditional parties do.



RANJAN RAHI

PK SPEAK

"Laluji has been a good father; he's thinking about making his son Bihar CM. Do you know what your children will do"

"If Lalu's regime was a jungle raj of criminals, Nitish's regime is a jungle raj of bureaucrats, who rule the state how they want"

"People have been voting for Lalu because they fear the BJP, or for Nitish and the BJP because they feared Lalu"

PK's response may well be that he's a universal alternative to all three big parties—he has vowed not to forge alliances with any of them. Politically, he's targeting both Nitish and Lalu for Bihar's immiseration. "If Lalu's regime was a jungle raj of criminals, Nitish's regime is a jungle raj of bureaucrats, who literally rule the state the way they want," says PK. Ironically, one of his hurrah moments as a strategist was the 2015 triumph of the Nitish-Lalu mahagathbandhan. In fact, his original debut in active politics was marked by a brief tenure as national vice-president of the JD(U), before Nitish expelled him from primary membership in January 2020 over ideological differences, particularly on the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA). In 2018, Nitish had surprised everyone by installing PK in that post, even calling him the future of Bihar.

Was he being prescient? Indeed, PK's biggest strength is that a cross-section of people in Bihar are drawn to his concept of alternative politics in a state that has seen just four chief ministers in 34 years. In 2025, though, if his pickings are modest, the question is: whose votes will he cut? Will he harm Tejashwi, who is presently convinced that the future belongs to him? Or Nitish, the original patent-holder to 'good governance' in Bihar? Or indeed, could it be the BJP, the other party operating from an elite-caste space? The psephologist in PK may have not taken a bet on that. ■